reserved for Lloyd George and his ‘system’ either. In 1921, the foreign secretary exchanged a series of heated notes with the then secretary of state for the colonies, Winston Churchill, on the latter’s supposed encroachment on Foreign Office issues.[29] And while some have argued that the end of Lloyd George’s term as prime minister ‘freed’ Curzon, the foreign secretary continued to chafe under Andrew Bonar Law (prime minister 1922–1923) and Stanley Baldwin (prime minister 1923-1924, 1924–1929 and 1935-1937).[30] Furthermore, despite his personal contempt for Curzon’s aristocratic background, Lloyd George did appreciate his foreign secretary’s capabilities and realised the importance of having him in the coalition.[31] One did not have to like the foreign secretary to respect him.

It was not only Curzon who fought against a demotion of Foreign Office influence in the years after 1918. Charles Hardinge was almost as important a political operator as Curzon. He had many years of experience in service of the foreign and diplomatic corps, and (like Curzon) had been Viceroy of India. While Hardinge’s relationship with Curzon was often contentious, both men did agree on the need to maintain Foreign Office hegemony over Britain’s foreign affairs.[32] In March 1918, Hardinge created the Political Intelligence Department (PID) under the tutelage of the Foreign Office in an effort to counter the Garden Suburb. Sometimes known as the ‘Ministry of All Talents’, the PID was an elite group of specialists tasked with providing the essential information needed for Britain to formulate its policy during the peace process.[33] How Lloyd George and his entourage chose to use such information while in Paris is another matter.[34] The important point is that the Foreign Office was not willing to go quietly into the night. And while Foreign Office officials were largely excluded from the high level decision making at Paris, their participation in the various sub-committees and commissions meant they were still able to influence the peace settlement. Eyre Crowe played a particularly strong role in Paris, occupying Britain’s seat when the senior statesmen were away, and ensuring the Foreign Office’s influence was felt.[35]

All of which is important in answering the question of who was ultimately responsible for the creation of Britain’s foreign policy in the post-war years. Together with housing some of the most experienced and capable men in the government, the Foreign Office was still the preeminent department for